The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

Iran delivered its response to **Donald Trump's** peace plan, according to Iranian state media. The regime's demands—attributed to an "informed official"—include compensation for war damage, an end to assassinations, guarantees that conflict won't restart and recognition of Iran's sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz. Another official boasted of Iran's readiness for ground combat, should America invade.

Mr Trump subsequently held a cabinet meeting without mentioning Iran's counterproposals. Instead, he repeated his claim that the country was "begging to make a deal". He said he was unsure if he was "willing" to reach an agreement, and didn't yet know if he might extend the Friday deadline for negotiations. The price of oil rose by roughly 5% and American stocks slid after his comments.

Israel claimed it killed **Alireza Tangsiri** (pictured), commander of the navy of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, in an air strike on Wednesday night. Israel's defence minister, Israel Katz, said Mr Tangsiri was "directly responsible" for the "bombing and blocking the Strait of Hormuz", which has disrupted global oil

supplies for weeks. Mr Katz said several other Iranian naval officials were killed in the attack.

The OECD warned that **global growth** would be weakened by the energy shock. The organisation predicted GDP would rise by 2.9% in 2026. It cut **Britain's** growth forecast for 2026 from 1.2% to 0.7%, the steepest downgrade of any G7 country. The OECD also warned of higher inflation, with prices in **America** expected to increase by 4.2% this year, up from 2.6% in 2025.

The **European Parliament** approved a **trade deal** with America, with some conditions. Lawmakers voted to delay EU tariff cuts until America lowers its rate on most European goods to 15%, as promised. A new clause gives the EU the right to scrap the agreement if America threatens member states' sovereignty, a nod to Mr Trump's desire to seize Greenland, a Danish territory.

The **International Olympic Committee** banned **transgender** women from women's events. The organisation will use a test for a gene known as SRY, which determines male sex, to uphold the rule. It said its decision "protects fairness, safety and integrity". Previously the committee had allowed individual sports to decide whether transgender athletes could compete at the games.

Last winter's **Arctic sea ice** was the smallest ever recorded for the second year in a row, according to analysis published by America's national satellite and ocean research agencies. The sea ice around the North Pole peaked at around 14m square kilometres, more than 2m square kilometres lower than the maximum extent recorded when records began in 1979, a reduction equivalent in size to Greenland.

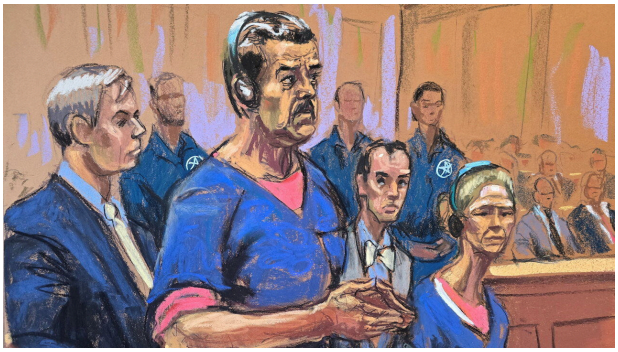
Figure of the day: $2.3bn, the value of De Beers, a diamond company, down from $12.75bn in 2011. Read about why Botswana's effort to buy a bigger chunk of De Beers could backfire.

Photograph: Getty Images

The known unknown for America and Iran

Donald Trump's claim that Iran is negotiating with America to end the war and that it has given America a "very big present" relating to oil and gas should be treated with a large dose of scepticism. It is neither clear who his Iranian interlocutors are—nor whether, if they do exist, they have any influence.

The negotiations are reportedly based on a 15-point plan drawn up last year, when the two countries sought to reach an agreement on Iran's nuclear programme, among other things. Iran's state media has mocked the president's claim. On Wednesday a military spokesperson said that Mr Trump was "negotiating with himself". Meanwhile thousands more US Marines as well as troops from the 82nd Airborne Division are on their way to the region. It is uncertain whether Mr Trump wants to de-escalate or simply calm jittery markets before beginning a new stage of the war. His inconsistency suggests he may not know himself.



Photograph: Reuters

Nicolás Maduro back in the dock

On Thursday Nicolás Maduro, Venezuela's former president, and his wife, Cilia Flores, are expected to appear before a judge in New York for the second time. The Trump administration, which seized the couple in Caracas on January 3rd, accuses Mr Maduro of four crimes, including conspiracy to commit "narco-terrorism" and to smuggle cocaine into America. Ms Flores is accused of similar crimes. Both deny the accusations.

At this hearing the defence will urge the judge to dismiss the case. They argue that the Trump administration has interfered by blocking the couple's access to Venezuelan government funds to pay their legal fees. The judge is highly unlikely to throw out the case. But this is only an early skirmish in a long and complex legal war. Vast reams of evidence must be gathered and shared, and then a trial date set. America's capture of Mr Maduro and Ms Flores was sudden and swift. Their trial will probably be anything but.

Illustration: David Simonds

Northern Europe strengthens its defences

On Thursday leaders of countries in the Joint Expeditionary Force, a northern European military alliance, gather in Helsinki. They will discuss their support for Ukraine and the overall state of European security. The British-led club has stepped up efforts to deter Russian aggression in the Baltic Sea, the North Atlantic and the Arctic. In September it will hold joint naval, air and land exercises, called Lion Protector, across Norway, Iceland and the Danish straits. It hopes to improve collaboration to protect infrastructure and to align command-and-control capabilities.

The Trump administration has been calling on Europe to do more to protect the High North. The JEF gives Britain a way to show leadership of Europe's response. The country is set to assume command of NATO's Atlantic and Arctic headquarters from America, and has committed more troops to defending the Nordic region. That may not placate Donald Trump, who has been berating Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, for failing to back America's war on Iran.

Joint Expeditionary Force members
Iceland
Finland
Russia
Norway
Estonia
Sweden
Latvia
Denmark
Lithuania
Ireland
Netherlands
Belarus
Britain
Poland
Germany
Ukraine
Bel.
Czech Rep.
Lux.
Slovakia
Aust.
Hung.
France
Romania

Photograph: Alamy

Novo weighs its future

Novo Nordisk holds its annual general meeting on Thursday at a difficult moment. The Danish drugmaker pioneered a new class of weight-loss medicines with the launch of Wegovy in 2021. Yet it has lost ground to Eli Lilly, an American rival. Lilly's weight-loss drug, Zepbound, now outsells Wegovy by more than two to one in America. Meanwhile, cheap copycats are conquering markets such as India and China, where patent protection for semaglutide, Wegovy's active ingredient, has expired. Novo's share price has fallen by more than three-quarters from its peak in June 2024.

The firm is fighting back. An oral version of Wegovy, launched in America in January, has been popular, though Lilly is expected to introduce its own pill soon. Novo has also struck a deal with Hims, a telehealth firm, which will now sell Wegovy instead of copycat versions of the slimming jab. Investors in Novo will hope to hear that the worst is over.

Shedding the pounds

Novo Nordisk, share price, $

Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Anna Maria Maiolino/Regina Vater

A lively show about ageing

Want to live longer? You're in luck: the effort to slow human ageing, long associated with quackery, is now all the rage. Serious-minded scientists and self-interested billionaires alike are looking to develop cutting-edge treatments to prolong lifespans.

A show opening on Thursday at the Wellcome Collection in London is one of the first museum exhibitions to explore the theme of ageing in science and culture. "The Coming of Age" displays objects such as a silver sake cup—the sort that Japan awarded to centenarians for decades, until they grew too numerous for the government to sustain the expense—and a walking stick carved from whalebone that was once owned by Charles Darwin. Artworks and vintage advertising show how contemporary beliefs about ageing have been shaped. A clip of "Don't Die", a documentary about Bryan Johnson, a venture capitalist who wants to live forever, plays on loop. The whimsical show fittingly bursts with life.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: In poker, what is the term for a hand that contains three of a kind and a pair?

Wednesday: What is the term for the annual celebration that occurs in many countries when the crops have been gathered?

Competitions are for horses, not artists.

Bela Bartok